Work-integrated learning: 14-week personal reflections

School A's background

I am doing my Work-Integrated Learning practicals at School A as a final year BEd student from the University of Pretoria. I'm going to write about the 7 weeks experience in this school and I will do it weekly. School A is a school located in a rural village. My teaching practicals will be from 13 April 2026 to 02 June 2026. I'm specializing in Sepedi FET(Grade 10-12). Despite the school being in a rural disadvantaged area, the school has Wi-Fi although all classrooms don't have electricity as a result of theft.

WEEK 1:

I was welcomed well by Principal (Teacher 1) on the 13th of April to the school. She then introduced me to the Head Of Department(HOD) of languages Teacher 2 so the She can assign me to a Mentor Teacher. The HOD was welcoming as well and she said to me "I'm going to assign you to the mentor teacher who's teaching the Most problematic classess", Teacher 3. The reason behind that was for me to strengthen my classroom management skills. I was assigned to the most loved teacher, Teacher 3 people(staff and Learners) like him because he is too friendly and accomodative. Spent 2 days preparing and observing other teachers' lessons in order to me to familiarize myself with their enviroment. On the 15th of April I started going to class to teach. Upon my arrival to the classroom I was amazed to find people my age and those who are older than me still in school. I introduced the lesson and started teaching. After the lesson I told all the learners that they will be assessed by a test every Friday in order for me to know if they are following and what should be repeated. The lesson did not go too well as the old problematic learners was doing by all means to interrupt the flow of the lesson, most of them they were not writing the class activities, not participating in class

as they say their teacher does not give them home works and class activities. It went like that until Friday (17th of April).

WEEK 2:

This week I am going to be introduced to the whole staff on Wednesday as we always have weekly briefing/meetings every Wednesday. On Monday I went to class to teach and I then found out that it's not just the issue of age that the learners have but also the concentration span. The learners have a short concentration span as a result the turn to be problematic in class, start roaming around the school, play by the toilets and also fight. Wednesday morning I was introduced to the staff by the Principal, and the school is composed of different tribes of teaching which is an interesting thing. There was a fight on Wednesday during break time, as a result of learners fighting over food. I have discovered that most of the learners in this school just came to school because they are forced not because the see a need for them to be in school, hence the school becomes so chaotic. The learners wrote an informal test based on the week 1 & 2 content. Most of them didn't perform well, and that guided me on what I should repeat and emphasise.

WEEK 3:

Because of the failing rate I have recorded from the informal test, I had to come with a strategy to tackles the issue of class interruption by the problematic learners as well as to capture and maintain the concentration of all the learners for them to do better in their studies. For me to be successful in doing so, I then started spending some time with them during break-time so that I can familiarize myself with their behaviour's outside the classroom. That was a way to build a good relationship between me and the learners. By doing so, I then discovered that what I have been suspecting is actually correct. This one old learner said to me "I am tired of coming to school and I honestly don't want to

but I’m forced by My parents hence I sell sweets here in school”. As Jean Twenge said, Gen Z learn best by virtual I then came with a different way of teaching and learning at School A. I changed the Standard traditional way of teaching using a chalkboard and I bought myself a mini projector and also creating slides using powerpoint. I also encouraged paired group discusions in my classroom as most of the learners were shy to voice out. I gave them exit ticket everyday even though at some point it was difficult to collect all of them because of the large number of learners in one class.

WEEK 4:

At 1st it became a challenges projecting slides to the learners as the classrooms had no electricity because of theft. I then had to come with my own electrical extension cord that I plugged in the Principals office. All the classes I taught then had to move faster quietly to the class that cord could reach. Me projecting slides captured most of the learners attention even those who are known to be problematic. They started gaining more interest in learning Sepedi and also started writing classwork and homeworks. On Monday, the last week’s fight escalated to this week and as a results it was now a mass fight were there were groups that badly injured. Later that week the school principal kicked some of those learners out of the school for good(expelled) because they discovered that those learners are smoking drugs like weed, nyaope as well as Crystal and some were given detention. On Friday they wrote a test based on week 3 & 4 content and the failing rate started to decrease and that was evident that the strategies I was using was partially working.

WEEK 5:

I am now to Familiar with the schools environment as well as learners. This week I discovered that some of the learner who aren’t doing/behaving well in school is because

of their home background, some don't receive the attention needed at school, some are abused and some are chandelled to choose the streams they don't want. Now my classes are interactive and they all get used to moving around whenever it's my period. Also the learner who are painted as bad by teachers are now able to come to me on their spare time to seek information, clarity and help with their school work(for all subjects). I help were I can, where I can't I then go to the teacher teaching that subject and ask for help then I deliver feedback to the learner. The relation I have with learners and teachers becomes tight. This week we had to repeat writing week 1 & 2's content so that we don't move without them understanding.

WEEK 6:

THE PRINCIPAL AND OTHER TEACHERS are amazed by the work I do and how I have managed to change learners who are known for not attending classes, those who are interruptive in the school to be the learners they are today(attending and respecting their teachers and also doing the work). Learners have started writing their MIDYEAR exams. Each and every morning before the classes commence I go and help preparing the papers that will be written that day. My lessons are now going smoothly everyone is engaged and Learners are now voluntarily starting to call me on my free period to come assist them where they are struggling. When I got there I would group them according to the areas that they are lacking in and give them a question/problem, let them discuss it first allow them to share their view points to the whole class and assist them where they are experiencing difficulties or misconceptions. Learners Are now used to writing weekly test and they are doing well.

WEEK 7:

The school is now on revision week and the school timetable changed in a manner that they extended the time a subject take from an hour to Two per day. The goal was for the

teachers to finish up revision as the started with the subjects Written 1st. This is also beneficial to learners as the MIDYEAR content covers work from term 1. We did a revision of everything we have covered for the term.

On Weekends:

THERE were learners who were volunteeringly coming to school. I also came so that I can be able to help them(tutoring). Most of the ones who were coming to school on weekends are the ones who were not performing well in the weekly tests and class activities. It was beneficial to them are they learned the content they find difficult at their own pace in my presence. I indeed has a great time at School A and if it was possible I was to continue with my 3rd quarter practicals there.

SCHOOL B's BACKROUND

I am doing my Work-Integrated Learning practicals at School B as a final year B.ED student from the University of Pretoria. I'm going to write about the 7 weeks experience in this school and I will do it weekly. School B is a school located in a township and the the school has diverse learners doing sesotho, affrikans, isixhosa and English as Home Language. My teaching practicals will be from 27 JULY 2026 to 15 SEPTEMBER 2026. I'm specializing in NATURAL SCIENCES SENIOR(Grade 8-9). Despite the school being in a TOWNSHIP area, the school doesn't have Wi-Fi although all classrooms don't have electricity as a result of the school being still newly under construction. The school is chaotic, learners are always outside the classroom and the school is populated by young adults(most of them their ages doesn't allow them to be in the grades they are in) , lastly the area itself is being ruined the initiation school stigma. As many people believe that when you from the initiation school you should be chaotic and becomes problematic as a result the school is dominated by bullying. I chose to relocate from a

village to a township because I believe in exploring , challenging myself and getting out of my comfort zone, so that when I am going to be appointed as a permanent educator ,relocating won't be a problem. I then found out that this area is populated by people who normalized drinking alcohol every day and the worse part of it is that most of them are the parents of the learners being taught at School B.

WEEK 1:

When I got there the Admin lady was very rude to me , as harmless as I was. I stood there and waited to see the principal, no one attended me for about 30min, after then there was this male teacher, Teacher 4, who came and asked why I'm at school, he then accompanied me to the principal's office. I was then welcomed by the acting Principal (Teacher 5). He referred me to Teacher 6 so that he can announce during assembly that they are having a student-teacher who's majoring in Natural Sciences. After assembly everyone left to their offices and classes. I was not directed to the Sciences Head Of Department, as they are the one to assign me a mentor teacher. I had to run around the school asking learners the directions to the science department head office. When I got there the office was locked. I had to stand outside the office hoping the the HOD will come. AFTER hour of standing there, the HOD arrived. I explained that I'm a student-teacher and will be doing my Work-Integrated Learning with them specializing in natural Sciences. The HOD was then happy to mentor me. She had 5 grade 9 classes(A-E). Grade 9 A: They are doing afrikaans, B&C: they are doing SESOTHO, D: English and E: Isixhosa as their home language. My mentor teacher then told me to prepare the lesson according to term 3 work stated on the Grade 9 Annual Teaching PLAN. The second day of me being there she then showed me the classes and introduced me to the grade 9s learners. On the 1st week we were doing forces , when I got to class the 1st day I presented my lesson and I was then assured by the learners that they loved and enjoyed the lesson, they told me that they enjoy the way I'm teaching natural sciences and the diagrams I was drawing for each an every aspect I was teaching them. I was using the drawing as learners has different ways of learning, that was helping them to understand the theory better. I was assessing them by giving them the class-

Activities, Home-Activities and class dicussions to measure their understanding. The learners were released early from school 2 consecutive days because of the school had water crisis and that was the real barrier to teaching and learning. That causes a delay in finishing the weekly syllabus stated on the Annual Teaching Plan.

WEEK 2:

On Monday morning I was helping my mentor teacher to create SBA TEMPLATES as well as capturing the term two marks on excel to see which topic were difficult and which ones needs to be re-taught. Some classes(grade 9 B and C) are just chaotic, they hinder a smooth progression of the lesson and it becomes difficult to assess their understanding of the content. The reason behind that is that these classes are dominated by learners that should be doing Grade 12 and some should be done with school. One of the Grade 09 E learner came to the office requesting to see his Term 2 script, Sadly he got 6/50 marks. I got curious and asked what's the problem? He then told me that my mentor teacher doesn't teach them due to their behavior. AT first I didn't believe him, I then checked all the scripts of the learners and I found out that 90% the learners scored below 10 Marks out of 50. The following day my mentor teacher went to 9E and the pushed the door in a way that she can't enter, after a while they ran to their seats. When the teacher asked "who was blocking the door?" no one answered. I then realise that the problem doesn't start within the school. On Friday learners were released early because there was a SADTU meeting.

WEEK 3:

ON Tuesday, it was announced that there's a grade 8 female learner that committed suicide. They said the reasons behind the learner committing suicide is the cyber bullying that initiated at school. I then realise that the main thing that is hindering the

progression of learning and learners finishing school on record time is bullying. I was in Grade 9D where I asked learners a question, one learner tried to give the answer and the other learner just spook out loud and said “WHAT KIND OF AN ANSWER IS THAT?”. I had to reprimand him as that kind of bullying will make other learners to be shy and afraid of answering as it will be like their opinions don’t matter. I have learned that the learners in this school deliberately do the things that are not acceptable and when you are trying to reprimand them THEY TRY BY ALL MEANS TO JUSTIFY THEIR ACTIONS AND EXPECT YOU AS A TEACHER TO UNDERSTAND WHY THEY ARE DOING THAT THING. They don’t want to own up to the wrong things they are doing rather they try to shift the blame to someone else. On the other hand most learners started showing interest in learning. It was evident that they enjoyed Sciences. The grade 9E started participating in class as they were happy that they are no longer being taught by my mentor teacher. I saw potential in them. We attended the memorial service of the learner committed suicide on Thursday. Learners were warned about cyber bullying as this whole thing ended up involving SAPS.

WEEK 4:

The District director together with the circuit manager visited our school on Monday after hearing about what happened. They had a meeting with the SMT and then after had a meeting with all the staff. The district director said “I came here to address the learners but after having a chat with the School Management Team(SMT), Ive discovered that the learners has no problems. The problems is with the teachers” he futher addressed the issue of Teacher absentism, teachers late arrivals at school and the physical fights amongst teachers at school. All of that was the results of why the learners are behaving the way they are. The Director futher mentioned that there’s a female teacher from the school that went to the district office to beg for promotion of being a principal and she said she can do whatever it takes to get the principal post. On the other hand my learners were now participating in class and when some were trying to disrupt the lesson I was using the technique of praise publicly and criticize privately.

That technique was working for me as I've realise that many learners here lack attention from home and the do whatever it takes to get the attention from learners and teachers and they do it in a wrong way. I was sure casing it to every learner that they are seen and that built a bond between me and the learners themselves. Later that week we attended the invigilating training that was conducted by the deputy principal. On Friday I went to another school to supervise the under 15 school soccer match.

WEEK 5:

ON MONDAY the circuit manager came with the the new appointed principal who was previously the Deputy Principal at a neighboring school from other township. The acting principal left with the circuit manager. The principal start Going around the school to familiarize himself with the environment and what he discovered was that the teachers doesn't attend to all their classess and learners are always roaming around outside during the school hours more especially Grade 8 and 9s. The principal the decided to start having meetings with the SMT everyday after morning briefing. The meetings were to ensure that the Departmental Heads pushes the Teachers in the department to start attending classes making sure that all the learners are in their classes during the teaching and learning hours, and to also make sure that the arrive to school on time. My mentor teaching came to observe my lesson and she was amazed and impressed at the same time when she found out that the learners can listen , behave and participate well in class with disrupting the lesson. She was in denial when I told her that the Grade 9E class is well behaved and they are showing a huge interest in learning Natural Sciences. through My observations to other teachers lessons I've discovered that some of the teachers in the school are there to just deliver the content. The dont care I learners are understanding, if learners are disruptive and if learners just go out of the class during their lessons. Later that week the SAPS visited the school after the saw a trending video on social media were learners were drinking alcohol inside the classroom wearing the school uniform.

WEEK 6:

The principal said everyday after 7:30 the teacher register book will be taken to his office so that he can be able to monitor the late comers. He also said when you are about to bunk school as a teacher, te principal has to be the 1st one to know. That Will monitor the teachers that just bunk the school without valid reasons and be able to take correct measures to deal with them. The principal also mentioned the issue of teachers not attending the classes more especially the last two periods of the day. And futher stated that those teachers are depriving the learners rights to learn. My mentor teaching went to Grade 9D to teach and the learners told her that they want to be taught by me , she came and called me and I taught the lesson . in each and every class she went the learners told her that they want to be taught by me. She looked at me as smiled after then she said; “Why does it seems like you are talking my job?”. I then saw the positive impact I have towards those learners and their studies. On Thursday the principal called the 1st staff meeting in his presence. The reason behind the meeting was to remind all the teachers their duties as teachers, why they are at school and how they should conduct themselves. The meeting was also about solving the personal fights teachers has and telling everyone that things are about to change and teachers will then need to adapt and obey to the new noms of doing things. The principal also issued out the daily classroom registers to keep track of learners who are attending and the ones who are attending. He also reminded the teachers that the should update their incident books on daily basis so that the school will be able to deal with troublesome learners. Lastly the principal proposed that the learners who achieved well in term 2 should get awarded as that will serve as a motivation to each and every learner to do well in their studies. On Friday I went to a local sports ground to supervise under 17 school soccer match.

WEEK 7:

ON MONDAY during assembly, learners who have done well in term 2 were called in front and awarded with the certificates and celebrated with music, it was to encourage learner whom have done well to continue and those who haven't to start pulling up their socks. This week was evident that the school is under a new leadership. The learners were always attended on time and the up and downs that was always made by the learners decreased. Some teachers were always asking me how do I manage to deal and keep order in the classrooms that are known to be problematic? I outlined that each and everyone deserve to be given a chance and everyone deserve to be seen and that is the strategy I use hence the learners feel free and safe around me as their teacher. The learners don't fail because they don't comprehend with what is being taught , the fail because the last the love of parents which they can also get from the teachers. They see no need of them being in school and excelling. They need a person to outline it to them why they are at school ad how that is going to be much beneficial to them in future. They were so emotional when they found out that it was my last week of me teaching them and I'm leaving. they were begging that atleast I should leave at the end of the year. My mentor teacher was also sad that I'm leaving and her last words to me was; "It was too soon for you to leave but you find it possible to do everything, however I will consider you having to work with me as my colleague in future you are a hard worker".